



SPRING ZING
Shivan & Narresh’s new collection reinterprets artist Hilma af Klint’s symbolic forms **P4**

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Size-zero reloaded

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Swetta Rao, a self-proclaimed “big girl”, has always been confident in her own skin. “I’m very comfortable with my weight, and am all for big girls, big people, for that matter,” says the Indore-based media professional. “I love my body for being supportive, despite all that I’ve put it through.” But as she has crossed over into her forties, she was forced to confront the impact of her weight on her health. “My knees tend to give up. Then, of course, there is managing my blood pressure,” says Swetta, who has tried working with a nutritionist, the gym, and 10,000 steps a day, but struggled to make a meaningful change. “I lost 15 kg, and then life happened, and I had to stop everything. Somehow, for someone juggling multiple roles and responsibilities, it has been tough.” Given her history, Swetta has now decided, with her doctor’s guidance, to give GLP-1 weight-loss drugs a chance, hoping that they will help her manage her health better. “It is not about being fat or not, but more from the health perspective,” she says.

Complex conversation

Her decision reflects a larger shift. As more people who once promoted a positive image of larger bodies opt for these drugs, the messaging around size and fitness is rapidly changing. Celebrities like Oprah Winfrey, Rebel Wilson, Lizzo and Meghan Trainor, who are noticeably thinner on GLP-1 weight loss drugs, were once loud cheerleaders for body positivity. The shift raises a question: what happens to body positivity when GLP-1 drugs get easier to access? Nayantra Menon Bagla, a Bengaluru-based nutrition and lifestyle coach, believes that the problem lies with the concept of body positivity itself. “I have often felt that the body positivity movement didn’t have the principles or larger structure that a

movement which lasts a long time should have. It was built on these very fragile ideas of acceptance, without being critical enough of health,” she says, adding, “I think it is an interesting conundrum for the body positivity movement, which was so weak at the core that it has pretty much crumbled.” According to Anshuma Kshetrapal, a Delhi-based drama and movement psychotherapist, the body positivity movement emerged in response to the idea that people were being judged based on appearance. She believes that equating thinness with health is a misnomer. “It is not

As weight loss drugs gain traction in India, they are reframing obesity as a chronic medical condition while raising questions about whether the body positivity movement can withstand a renewed push towards thinness



about thin versus obese at all, but rather about removing appearance as a factor of judgment for health,” she says. “The core idea being that you should not be considering them a burden to society’s resources, or calling them lazy.” The drugs are rapidly changing how obesity is understood. Dr Rajeev Kurapati, a US-based triple-board-certified physician in family, obesity, and lifestyle medicine, describes it as a “chronic, relapsing disease”. Author of *The Book of Body Positivity: How We Got It All Wrong and What We Can Do about It*, explains how “That takes the burden off a person and onto the medical community.” GLP-1 is central to this shift. In Dr Rajeev’s opinion, “if a person is genuinely obese and struggling with weight loss, these drugs actually empower them,” he says, cautioning, however, that the drugs can have side effects and should be used in addition to lifestyle modifications.

(Clockwise from left) A woman strength trains; Rebel Wilson in her new avatar; a GLP-1 injection; and Oprah Winfrey at the 81st Annual Golden Globe Awards in Beverly Hills. REUTERS

But given that trends indicate the usage of these drugs is only going to increase, particularly in India as prices fall, will this lead to the collective idolisation of extreme thinness? How does one prevent the misuse of these drugs in the pursuit of a dream body, given the country’s inadequate drug regulatory system?

Get thin quick schemes

Earlier this month, counterfeit versions of Mounjaro, valued at around ₹56 lakh, were discovered during a crackdown in Gurugram, highlighting the ease of access to GLP-1 in India. In a country where prescription regulations are notoriously weak, the misuse of what should be a highly-regulated drug is inevitable. Already, wellness clinics and doctors in cities like New Delhi, Mumbai, and Bengaluru are creating bridal packages by bundling Mounjaro jabs with makeovers. GLP-1 drugs are also being used before red-carpet appearances, holidays or even just to fit into a pair of old jeans last worn in the 90s. Anshuma worries that these drugs will become “a way of creating a new normal around thinness.” In

fact, that is precisely what body positivity came up in response to: “This obsession with thinness as health, with clavicle showing, the ribs showing. Not every body is supposed to look like that in health. For some, that’s a really extreme way to live.” The idealisation of extreme thinness, after all, is deeply political, often linked to more conservative political structures that inherently seek to disempower women. As Nayantra puts it, the glorification of a slimmer, smaller female body is simply one more way of policing it. “Every time there is a surge in women’s voice, and they begin taking up more space in the public domain, skinny comes back in fashion. If you really think about it, keeping them undernourished and obsessed with their size, they lose sight of the bigger picture, whether it was the heroin chic era of the 90s or the flapper era of boyish bodies,” she says.

A necessary option

Delhi-based Preksha has always believed that all shapes and sizes are beautiful. “I used to comment on reels that talked about body positivity,” she says. But the lived experience of having to inhabit a bigger body was not pleasant, from what she remembers.

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pick of the week



Fresh off the grill

Cappella at The Palomar by Crossway, Chennai, continues to showcase varieties of kebabs as part of its ongoing 45-day fest Kebab-e-Khaas. The options, both vegetarian and meat-forward, range from pan-fried to tandoor grills. Expect bhuna tandoori aloo, chapli kebab, murgil gillafi kebab, kalonji jhinga, and raan-e-murg. Available for lunch and dinner till May 31. A meal for two costs ₹2,000; call 8925847085 for reservations.



Retro grade!

Fizzy Goblet, a brand known for handcrafted footwear and bags, is channelling the elements of retro fashion — polka dots, floral prints and lace — in its new collection Vintage Baddies. The drop features beadwork, schiffli embroidery, and lace detailing on shoulder bags, ballet flats, sandals, mule heels and criss-cross wedges, priced between ₹3,990 and ₹8,990. The edit is available at Fizzy Goblet stores across India and on fizzygoblet.com.



Hound for décor

The Mudhol hound, an indigenous dog breed, is the mascot of Citrus Zest, the latest collection of design-led lifestyle brand Chumbak. Inspired by Indian summer, the brand's cushions, wall art, serveware, storage solutions, tabletop accents, and bags interweave the motifs of the hound with citrus fruits; think lemon-shaped trays and hand-painted stoneware. Available at the brand's stores across India and at chumbak.com, from ₹499.



Forming narratives

Art Amalgam's second edition at Apparao Galleries, Chennai, spans five shows. Cartography of Identity maps memory. The Phenomenology of Resilience engages with botanical forms. The Cast and the Carved examines material transformation, while Mapping the Ritual—Real (by Srinivasa Reddy) navigates myth. The Imagined Pantheon (by Sitikantha and Madan Meena) reinterprets miniature traditions. On till July 31; Tuesday to Saturday, 3pm to 6.30pm.

Barry Rodgers

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There is a particular modern-world anxiety that clings to the idea of an open relationship: that it is either a sign of the evolution of a romantic equation or a prelude to collapse. In India, where the language of desire still struggles to keep pace with the reality of it, the question feels especially loaded: does opening a relationship save it, or simply delay its end?

The numbers suggest we are, at the very least, willing to entertain the possibility of having an open relationship. A 2023 study by dating app Bumble found that nearly 60% of Indian singles are open to ethical non-monogamy, while a 2025-26 survey by Gleeden, the dating app for discreet encounters, in partnership with market research firm IPSOS, reported that 69% of Indians believe such arrangements are becoming socially acceptable. What, exactly, are we agreeing to, and who, precisely, has read the fine print.

Who's going to tell them?

A psychologist I spoke to in 2023 said we tend to treat the suggestion of an open relationship as a verdict rather than a conversation. In psychological terms, this reflects a kind of normative monogamy bias — the belief that any deviation from exclusivity signals failure. "People hear 'open' and assume 'ending,'" she told me. "So they refuse to engage with what's actually being asked." It is a curious reflex: we would rather preserve the appearance of stability than examine its contents.

What complicates this further is the role of shame. In a culture that associates marriage with aspiration and expectation, the space to articulate sexual variance is limited. We are, as she put it, "conditioned into a script before we have the vocabulary to question it". Many

THE NAKED TRUTH
It's complicated

With rising acceptance of ethical non-monogamy in India, couples are testing whether openness strengthens relationships

people enter long-term partnerships before they have fully understood their own desires; exploration, then, arrives belatedly, layered with obligation and the occasional existential audit. "I would never advise someone to open a relationship," she added, "just as I would never advise someone to get married." Both, she implied, are decisions people make with great confidence and very little rehearsal.

For a close friend of mine, that fluency was hard-won. Four years into a relationship that had begun to feel, in her words, "politely stagnant" — the kind that looks perfectly functional from the outside — she and her partner arrived at an impasse. "He is affectionate, deeply so," she says, "but not particularly adventurous. And I realised, slowly, that I was." The discrepancy did not present itself as conflict so much as absence — a sense that something unarticulated was shaping the edges of their intimacy.

What followed was a series of negotiations. They spoke about desire, at first, almost clinically: what was wanted, what was not, and what might be possible without destabilising what already existed. Eventually, they agreed

to open the relationship, but with a structure that resisted secrecy. Encounters would be shared and nothing would occur in isolation. "So we decided if we do this, we do it together." Not so much an open relationship as a group project with unusually high stakes.

The arrangement did not so much transform their relationship as recalibrate it. A period of inertia gave way to something more playful. They

have now been together for 10 years. Marriage, they say, is beside the point. "We're not trying to fix something broken," she adds. "We're trying to keep something alive." Which, in long-term relationships, is no small feat.

If my friend's story comes across as a carefully managed expansion, a former colleague's arrangement is a reminder of how easily the language of openness can be misapplied.

"My partner at the time proposed an open relationship with the assurance that it would strengthen what they had." She hesitated, but agreed. "There's a certain performance to being 'okay' with things now," she notes. "I think I confused that with actually being okay."

A confusion that exists alongside another performance — the reflexive allegiance to monogamy as the moral high ground.

At first, the arrangement was framed as mutual exploration. But the symmetry did not hold. "I realised that what we had wasn't openness," she says. "It was permission granted very unevenly."

Her critique is not of non-monogamy itself, but of the conditions required to sustain it. "People assume it's easier," she says. "In reality, open arrangements demand more communication and more honesty than most couples are used to." In India, she argues, this difficulty is amplified by a broader discomfort with desire. "We don't talk about what we want, not without shame. So when you introduce a structure that depends entirely on transparency, it exposes how little practice we have at telling the truth."

The relationship did not survive.

If monogamy has long functioned as a default, it is perhaps because it allows certain questions to remain unasked. Non-monogamy, by contrast, insists on articulation. It demands a level of emotional literacy that cannot be outsourced to convention.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



Clutch with a whimsical touch

With crystal-studded minaudières shaped like parrots, cakes and curios, Judith Leiber brings its fun, maximalist bags to Delhi

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Spanning a 70-year legacy, Judith Leiber Couture's bags, clutches and miniatures have been red carpet staples, conversation starters that bring crystal-studded whimsy to any evening. Its famed minaudières, small evening bags sculpted into quirky, artistic forms, have long been considered objets d'art, cementing their status as coveted collectibles.

Closer home, the brand has re-entered India's luxury retail space with a brick-and-mortar store at The Chanakya in Delhi. The brand's first foray into the Indian market was over a decade ago, with the Marigold Group which opened a flagship store at DLF Emporio in New Delhi.

While the Delhi-versus-Mumbai fashion debate continues, the choice of

Delhi felt natural, says Chandni Agarwal, chairman, managing director and founder, Sparsh India Couture, the retail arm of Sparsh Industries leading the India launch now. "Delhi has always been the heartbeat of India's luxury landscape. It has evolved from consumption to curated appreciation; everyone here wants the best," she says. With the Indian luxury market projected to touch nearly \$14 billion by 2026, Chandni, who is also the India spokesperson for Judith Leiber Couture, notes that Delhi continues to hold the largest share. "With new luxury malls and evolving



(Clockwise from left) The Elephant Majestic minaudière by Judith Leiber; the brand's retail space in The Chanakya; Parrot Bali minaudière. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



retail spaces, there's little comparison with any other city right now," she adds.

At The Chanakya, the intimate, compact store of 192 square feet — "like stepping into a jewel box," as Chandni describes it — features a curated edit of signature silhouettes, including bow top handle bags and crystal-studded minaudières. The compact space, she says, was intentionally designed, as one in which customers can engage closely with the craftsmanship on each piece.

The sparkling minaudières on display take the form of French fries, cupcakes, London's red phone booths, crowns, tiaras, espresso martinis and butterflies. There are also designs tailored for the Indian market, such as the Parrot Scarlet, Elephant

Majestic, famously carried by Guneet Monga at the Academy Awards for *The Elephant Whisperers*, and the Ganesh Shri minaudières.

The curation reflects the Indian luxury consumer: someone who styles for both contemporary evenings and grand weddings, where traditional craftsmanship and overall styling come together.

Chandni believes the brand's aesthetic aligns naturally with Indian sensibilities, especially among younger buyers. "We love celebration and ornamentation. While earlier generations leaned towards logos, Gen Z is driven by storytelling, versatility and emotional connection," she says.

Alongside the current selection, the store will see seasonal drops and India-exclusive pieces. "We'll also respond to customer feedback and evolve the curation, while working with the brand on more India-specific designs," Chandni adds.

Judith Leiber Couture is now at The Chanakya, Delhi. Prices upwards of ₹1.25 lakh.

An Americano to match your bag

Tory Burch's Delhi takeover turns its Romy bag into a coffee experience where sipping meets styling

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We have heard of bar takeovers by mixologists and kitchen takeovers by chefs. But the ongoing 15-day takeover at Roastery Coffee House in Delhi's Sarvodaya Enclave is by American luxury brand Tory Burch.

Titled The Romy Café, this experience is inspired by Tory Burch's Romy collection that ranges from ₹35,000 to ₹75,000, depending on the size, material, and style.

These bags, including the Romy tote, Romy bucket bag, and Romy shoulder bag, are exhibited at the café.

The outlet translates the Romy bag into a series of functional, collectible elements. A sculptural Romy installation welcomes guests at the entrance. Inside, the café is detailed with elements that reflect the brand's design language: custom table settings, branded coffee cups and sleeves, bespoke dessert packaging, and a specially created café menu by Roastery Coffee House.

It features the outlet's best-selling coffees — cranberry coffee, latte and Americano. The food menu comprises Romy cupcake, croissants, choux pastries and vol au vents.

Anshi Saxena, co-founder, Roastery Coffee House, says, "The collaboration with Tory Burch felt deeply personal. Our work has always been about representing Indian speciality coffee in its truest form — celebrating coffees grown on our soil, along with Indian aesthetics, craftsmanship, and a warmth in hospitality that feels natural, not performed." She also said that it was interesting creating this vibe where style and coffee sat together



(Above) Roastery Coffee House reimagined as The Romy Café by Tory Burch; (below) customised latte art at the takeover. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

effortlessly. "This collaboration was shaped over two-and-a-half months, from the launch of the Romy Collection (on April 23) until May 10," she added.

A statement from Tory Burch says: "Roastery Coffee House was a deliberate choice, grounded in a shared commitment to craftsmanship, community, and considered experiences. The collaboration was

also intentionally anchored in partnering with a woman entrepreneur — creating space to spotlight her voice and journey. By aligning with an artisanal coffee house, the focus remains on individuality, quality, and the beauty of thoughtful making."

The Romy Café at Roastery Coffee Shop will be on till May 10 at Sarvodaya Enclave, New Delhi.



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Rihanna did not build Fenty Beauty as a conventional beauty label. When it launched in 2017 under Kendo, a San Francisco-based incubator owned by LVMH Moët Hennessy Louis Vuitton, the premise was both simple and quietly radical. Forty foundation shades at debut, now expanded to 50-plus, were positioned as a correction.

It is worth noting that Fenty was not operating in a vacuum. MAC Cosmetics had long been considered a pioneer in shade diversity, particularly through the 1990s and 2000s, with its Studio Fix range becoming an industry benchmark for undertone matching. But it was only in 2018, in the wake of what came to be known as the “Fenty effect,” that MAC expanded its foundation lineup significantly to around 60 shades, reflecting a broader industry shift.

That idea travelled fast because it exposed an absence that the industry had long normalised. As reported by *Business of Fashion*, *WWD*, and *Forbes*, Fenty Beauty crossed \$100 million in sales within its first 40 days, a figure that signalled more than commercial success. Fenty Beauty has been widely pegged at around \$2.8 billion in 2025-26, though more recent estimates suggest that number may be under pressure as the category matures. The industry responded quickly, expanding shade ranges and rethinking representation, turning what had once been a marginal conversation into a baseline expectation.

The grand show

At the centre of Fenty Beauty’s Mumbai takeover was a structure that said everything without quite saying it outright. Fenty ki Haveli, a limited pop-up at Phoenix Palladium, Lower Parel in Mumbai, running through May 4 is more of a stage set since Fenty launched in India last year.

Inside, the brand’s global bestsellers are arranged with studied precision: the Pro Filt’r Soft Matte and Hydrating Foundations, the Gloss Bomb Universal Lip Luminizers, lip stains and tints, highlighters, contour sticks, the full architecture of a line that has already proven itself elsewhere.

The haveli itself, ornate and



The Fenty flex

From the hype around the Mumbai pop-up, Fenty ki Haveli, to a high-visibility rollout, Rihanna’s brand has plenty going for it — but can performance outpace hype in a crowded, price-sensitive market

deliberately local, feels like an attempt to anchor a global brand within an Indian imagination of luxury.

Hovering just beneath the spectacle, however, was another narrative, one that has more to do with power. Through Sephora India, operated by Reliance Retail and overseen by Isha Ambani, this launch was always going to be a flex.

That control is not incidental. In November 2023, Reliance Retail acquired the rights to operate Sephora in India from Arvind Fashions in a ₹99.02 crore deal, taking over 26 stores across 13 cities. The move consolidated a significant portion of India’s premium beauty retail landscape under one umbrella.

The evening carried that same energy. Rihanna, still the gravitational centre of the brand, was ushered from one room to another, her presence carefully rationed.

Guests, including influencers and

journalists, waited well past midnight, some until nearly 1.30am, for a moment that lasted seconds.

India, with its varied skin tones, would seem like a natural next step. The market is at an inflection point, with homegrown brands building loyal followings and consumers growing more discerning. For context, by 2030, India is projected to become the fourth-largest beauty and personal care market globally, reaching \$40 billion, according to market research firm RedSeer.

For Chennai-based makeup artist Madhu Ravichandran, Fenty’s appeal predates its arrival in India. “I first bought Fenty’s foundation when it wasn’t even available here,” she says, recalling how she sourced it through a friend travelling from Dubai. What stayed with her was the consistency of the formulations. Among her go-to products is the contour stick, which she describes as a rare mainstay in an industry

defined by constant churn. “It’s been a cult favourite for seven, eight years now, which is no small feat,” she notes.

Where the conversation becomes more layered is pricing. In India, Fenty sits slightly above US parity once import duties and GST are factored in. The Pro Filt’r Foundation, priced at around \$40 (roughly ₹3,300), typically retails between ₹3,800-₹4,200 locally. The Eaze Drop Skin Tint, at \$36, lands closer to ₹3,200- ₹3,600.

That recalibration becomes more pronounced when placed against alternatives. While Huda Beauty sits in a similar



(Clockwise from left) Rihanna; Fenty caters to a diverse mix of skin tones; Fenty products; and Rihanna at the launch of Fenty Beauty brand in Mumbai on April 24. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



price bracket, Indian labels such as Fae Beauty offer comparable formats at ₹500-₹800.

For Aatef Bham, co-founder of Mumbai-based digital marketing agency Togglehead, the more meaningful shift is happening on the consumer side.

“The Indian beauty industry has never really been truly loyal,” he says, “but that’s beginning to change.”

That complicates Fenty’s entry. “They’re not just competing with global brands,” he notes. “They’re up against legacy players and aggressive Indian brands.”

The first purchase is almost inevitable. “People will try it once.” What follows is harder. “At that price, the formula

has to overdeliver. If it doesn’t, you get punished.”

Local brands, he adds, are increasingly efficient. “They’re offering maybe 70-80% of the performance at 20-30% of the price.” This leaves little room for branding alone.

Rare Beauty, fronted by Selena Gomez, and launched in India in June 2023 through Sephora India, offers a useful counterpoint. The brand generated approximately \$367 million in global revenue in 2023, according to Forbes, and is valued at over \$1.3 billion, with broader industry estimates placing it above \$2 billion as it continues to scale globally, as reported by Wikipedia and industry analyses. It is tempting to imagine that, had the launch taken place post Reliance Retail’s takeover of Sephora India later that year, it might have unfolded with a very different kind of scale.

What Fenty has, unmistakably, is attention. Once the haveli is dismantled and the spectacle recedes, what remains is not the memory of the night, but the question of the morning after.

Inside India’s painted heartland

Journey through Shekhawati, where frescoed havelis, historic towns, and cultural festivals trace the afterlife of a mercantile desert civilisation

Satarupa Paul

“This haveli is at least a hundred years old, so are the frescos in your room,” the bellman tells me proudly as he opens the low wooden door that requires you to bend to enter. After five hours on the road from Delhi, I am eager to rest before heading out to explore Churu, one of several towns where you can experience the faded grandeur of Shekhawati. Often described as the world’s largest open-air art gallery, this region in northern Rajasthan is known for its dense concentration of 18th-20th Century merchant havelis hand-painted with intricate frescoes.

What I do not yet realise is that my exploration has already begun, right here inside my room at Malji Ka Kamra, one of several havelis now restored as heritage hotels. It blends Italianate details with Rajput architecture, featuring Corinthian columns, arched balconies and stained glass. My cavernous room is overwhelming for eyes untrained to such scale and maximalism. Frescos cover every inch of wall and ceiling – some vivid, others fading and peeling like fragile relics. They depict portraits of former owners, floral motifs, scenes of daily life, angels with wings, and faraway places shaped by travel.

Named after one of the region’s three districts, alongside Jhunjhunu and Sikar, Churu is easy to overlook at first. Broken roads, a busy railway

crossing, and a dusty marketplace lead to the old town centre, where narrow lanes reveal a compact grid of havelis. Built around 1870, the Surana Haveli, with 1,111 windows and doors designed for ventilation, is locally known as the Hawa Mahal of Churu. The Mantri Haveli, one of the oldest in town, remains fully covered in frescos. Amid these private residences stands the Bhagwan Shri Shantinath Jain Temple, its white marble exterior offering visual relief from the intricate frescos within.

On the edge of Churu lies Sethani Ka Johara, a historic stepwell built during the severe famine of 1899. Today, it is one of Shekhawati’s most contemplative spaces, where I find myself one evening immersed in a powerful cello recital by maestro Saskia Rao-de Haas, as part of the VHAH Fest. Framed by stone arches and chhatris, the performance offers a fitting close to my week in Shekhawati, shaped by art, history, and culture.

The making of Shekhawati Shekhawati’s story begins in the 15th Century, when the Rajput chieftain Rao Shekha established control over this semi-arid region. Its location along caravan routes linking Agra and Delhi to western India soon turned it into a thriving trading corridor, with commerce in cotton, silk, spices, and opium flowing steadily. Marwari and Jain traders prospered here, and by the 18th and 19th centuries, their wealth



(Clockwise from left) A restored haveli in Mandawa painted with vibrant frescos; a session during the 10th edition of VHAH Fest at Ramgarh Fort; and the interiors of a Jain temple in Churu. SATARUPA PAUL



found architectural expression with grand havelis commissioned across three districts. Today, these havelis stand as enduring records of a mercantile culture that once flourished here.

In Bollywood

Mandawa is undoubtedly Shekhawati’s most recognisable

destination, featuring memorably in films like *Bajrangi Bhaijaan*, *PK*, *Jab We Met* and others. The small town reveals itself best on foot, as I discover on my heritage walk with the young and deeply informed Mudita Saxena, Shekhawati’s first female tourist guide authorised by the



Ministry of Tourism. Around Mandawa Castle, its medieval Rajputana architecture dominating the skyline, are the finest havelis – the Goenka Double Haveli, Murmuria Haveli, Chowkhani Double Haveli, to name a few – each layered with vibrant frescoes. A pause at the Murmuria Tank, an old stepwell once central to town

life, offers a quiet contrast. A short drive away, Vivaana Culture Hotel feels like a natural extension of the walk – an imposing 19th-Century double haveli where frescoes, courtyards, and craft traditions are not preserved behind glass, but lived with daily.

The region’s folklore

Half an hour down the road, Nawalgarh feels less visited and more lived in. I spend the better part of my time at Vivaana Museum Hotel, housed in a 150-year-old Jaipuria haveli restored under conservationist Atul Khanna’s vision.

The space is a fine example of adaptive reuse, where original architectural details remain the focus. The ground floor doubles as a compact museum, offering insights into Shekhawati’s folklore and domestic life, while folk performances and village walks extend the experience beyond the haveli. One such walk leads me to the Dr. Ramnath Podar Haveli Museum, among the oldest and largest private museums in India.

Ramgarh Shekhawati

About two hours away, through fields of mustard and open countryside, Ramgarh Shekhawati, once a major centre of Sanskrit learning and Ayurvedic medicine, was known as Doosra Kashi. Today, its havelis, stepwells, chhatris, and fort still reflect that legacy.

I arrive during the 10th edition of the annual Vedaaranya Heritage and Healing Festival (VHAH Fest), envisioned by Ramgarh native and heritage conservationist Shruti Nada Poddar. At Ramgarh Fort, I move from a UNESCO-led panel to a Kathak recital, from a dastaangoi to a thrilling performance by percussion ensemble Tal Fry.

Between discussions, performances, and heritage walks through MOHAR Haveli (Museum of Heritage & Art), Vedaaranya Haveli, stunning century-old cenotaphs, and temples, Ramgarh momentarily feels like its old self again.



A Swedish spring in India

Shivan & Narresh's new collection Springlie reinterprets artist Hilma af Klint's symbolic forms and colour energy through contemporary resortwear silhouettes

Geetika Sachdev

For designers Shivan Bhatiya and Narresh Kukreja of Shivan & Narresh, resortwear has long been positioned as more than holiday dressing. Since launching their label in 2010, the duo has framed the category as clothing shaped by travel, leisure and celebration – garments designed to move easily between settings. Their latest collection,

Springlie, continues that exploration while drawing from the abstract visual language of Swedish painter Hilma af Klint, whose work is recognised for symbolic motifs, fluid geometry and bold colour compositions. “The visions of Hilma af Klint feel remarkably contemporary despite being created over a century ago,” says Shivan. “What drew us most was her ability to merge spirituality with abstraction, creating a

visual language that explores energy and balance.”

Reinterpreting spring Across the collection, spiralling forms, graphic lines and layered colour blocks create a sense of movement. The womenswear line includes swimsuits and ready-to-wear pieces – in lightweight fabrics like silk and organza – such as rompers, jumpsuits, palazzos, dresses,

kaftans and tops, alongside occasion wear like tiered skirts, embellished lehengas and draped gowns. Menswear ranges from polos and shirts to printed denim trousers and kurta sets. For Narresh, the starting point was not simply the visual vocabulary of the paintings but the ideas behind them. “We begin by studying the philosophy and emotional energy within her work rather

than simply adapting the imagery,” he explains. “From there, those ideas evolve into prints, colour palettes and silhouettes that echo her sense of movement.” The collection also moves away from the delicate hues typically associated with spring fashion. Instead, shades such as cobalt blue and high-contrast graphic

motifs dominate. “Spring is often imagined through pastels, but for us the season also carries a sense of awakening,” says Narresh. “With Springlie, we wanted to capture that expressive side of the season.”

Ease and structure Movement remains central to the

label's design language, and the silhouettes in Springlie reflect what the designers describe as “fluid strength”. “We explored silhouettes that move with ease through draped lines, elongated forms and relaxed tailoring while still holding a sense of structure,” says Shivan. Flowing silks, lightweight fabrics like cotton, organza and tulle, and sculptural swimwear create garments that respond to the body's

movement, while textured jacquards add visual depth. The designers say fabric experimentation plays a key role in translating the collection's artistic references into wearable pieces. “Fabric is more than a base,” Narresh adds. “It becomes the medium through which colour, print and craftsmanship come together.”

Resortwear beyond holidays When Shivan & Narresh first introduced luxury resortwear in India, the category itself was relatively unfamiliar in the domestic market. Over the past decade, however, the context for such clothing has broadened. Destination weddings, honeymoons and milestone celebrations have expanded the occasions where resort-inspired silhouettes are worn. As a result, versatility has become an increasingly important consideration in the design process. “We focussed on silhouettes that feel effortless yet refined, allowing them to transition easily from day to evening,” explains Narresh.

Extending the wardrobe Accessories appear as an extension of the collection's visual language. Pieces such as the Olly tote bag, artisanal visors and leather slides echo the colours and graphic motifs seen in the garments, carrying the abstract references into smaller design elements. “For us, accessories are never just finishing touches,” says Shivan. “They are independent design statements that complement the wardrobe while also standing on their own.” In translating the symbolic geometry and colour energy of Hilma af Klint into garments designed for movement, Springlie reflects how art continues to find new interpretations within fashion.

Upwards of ₹15,950 at Shivan and Narresh stores across the country and on shivanandnarresh.com



Size-zero reloaded

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Being overweight, for instance, had a negative impact on her mental health. “I even stopped shopping for new clothes at one point,” says Preksha. In her opinion, many of the body positive influencers end up struggling with various medical conditions. “I wanted to be healthy,” says Preksha, who has finally managed to get her PCOS and sugar under control after losing nearly 30 kilograms on Mounjaro, one of several GLP-1 drugs in the Indian market. But weight-loss doesn't just lead to physical change. “As someone who has inhabited a bigger body and gone through multiple cycles of weight loss and gain, the body dysmorphia continues to kick in on some days,” says Nayantara, who firmly believes that Indian therapists and mental health



professionals will have to really pivot to keep pace with changes in the larger health ecosystem, something Dr Rajeev, too, agrees with. He believes that GLP-1 drugs should be taken only by people who are struggling to lose weight and have medical conditions because of the

GLP-1 drugs need to be accompanied by lifestyle changes; (below) Kate Moss. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

excess weight. “These drugs help people who are in genuine medical need, but they will create a problems for people who are looking for a quick fix,” he says. If one is using these drugs simply to fit into a dress, without adopting more sustainable, long-term lifestyle changes, “you may look thinner, but you will still be unhealthy”.

You still need to lift weights Ahmedabad-based Himani Raj, who has been on Mounjaro since July last year and now runs two support and accountability groups for Indian men and women on GLP-1s, echoes the same view. “Being five or 10 kgs overweight is very different from being 50 or 60 kgs

overweight,” says Himani, who weighed over 150 kgs when she started her journey. “There were so many things that came with weight: high cholesterol, triglycerides out of the charts, irregular menstrual cycles, pre-diabetes,” she says. More than her weight, it was about getting those markers under control that emboldened her to try out these drugs, assisted by a good endocrinologist, she says. “I was not very hopeful because I had tried so many other things, and nothing had worked out.” Her actual experience of using the drug in addition to targeted lifestyle changes, including regular exercise and a high-protein, calorie-controlled diet, has proved to be largely positive. “It has been great so far,” admits Himani, who has dropped around 32 kgs since she started. In addition to the weight loss, “my pre-diabetes has been reversed, my PCOS is under control: I have better skin and hair health....”

While she does often share all that she has learned on this journey with her support groups, she is clear about this: “You have to visit a doctor if you feel that you are obese and want yourself to be evaluated,” she says, agreeing that these drugs are often misused. The question is no longer whether these drugs work, but how they will be used. GLP-1 can broaden our approach to fitness or take us back decades to a deep-rooted, fixation with skinny chic.



(Clockwise from right) A cheese platter; fresh cream cheese; and halloumi. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



When bhoot jolokia met cheddar

Queso, Assam's first artisanal small-batch cheese brand from Dibrugarh, is making waves for blending European tradition with Assamese flavours

Kasturi Das

The quaint city on the banks of the Brahmaputra river, Dibrugarh in Assam, is home to some of the oldest and largest tea estates in the country. Now, it is also in the news for experiments with cheese.

Queso, the State's first artisanal small-batch cheese brand, blends European tradition with Assamese flavours. Its bestseller is the bhoot jolokia cheddar, a daring fusion of Assam's iconic chilli with creamy cheddar; the bhoot jolokia adds heat to the tangy and nutty cheddar.

Another crowd-favourite is Parmesan and garlic cheddar. "By artisanal, I mean everything we make is from 100% pure milk," says Abhilasha, the founder of Queso. "For most of us growing up, 'cheese' meant blocks made from milk solids, not pure milk. My journey really began from questioning that difference."

"In India, there are around 15 artisanal cheesemakers right now, and most of them focus on the traditional European style of cheesemaking," says Abhilasha. According to experts, what makes cheese artisanal is the craft and scale. It is typically handcrafted in small batches using traditional methods and high-quality ingredients and minimal or no additives.

Abhilasha's foray into cheesemaking was accidental. After years of working in Dubai and Gurugram with a French company building thermal and solar power plants, she moved back to Dibrugarh during the pandemic. There, she opened Windsong Café in 2022. And soon, she realised, she needed a lot of cheese for the pasta and pizza they served everyday.

Abhilasha reached out to several cheesemakers across India, but none could supply to her café due to the lack of dependable cold-chain logistics.

For most of us growing up, 'cheese' meant blocks made from milk solids, not pure milk

ABHILASHA
Founder, Queso



So she began experimenting with mozzarella and cream cheese, then went on to train at the Academy of Cheese in the UK. "While studying, I discovered that India is the world's largest milk producer, and yet, we are still feeding our children processed cheese," says

Abhilasha. "I thought, why import when we have such good milk here."

Queso, which means cheese in Spanish, was launched in early 2023. They now make around 20 varieties of cheese. As small-batch artisanal cheesemakers, a lot of their

processes are manual. The team now produces small wheels of cheese, up to five kilograms each, using milk sourced from cows that graze freely in the green fields of Bogibeel, a rural locality situated a few kilometres from Dibrugarh, across the Brahmaputra.

"Whatever the cows graze on reflects directly in the cheese. Summer milk is leaner, producing lighter cheese. Winter milk has more fat, creating a buttery flavour. That's the beauty of artisanal cheese – it changes with the seasons," Abhilasha explains.

Among the different kinds of cheeses that are crafted by the Queso team, like garlic cheddar, basil gouda, smoked gouda, Tomme, provolone, halloumi, and Parmesan, is an interesting variety called the Morbier cheese – a traditional French cheese known for its smooth texture and distinctive appearance, which is mixed with *khar* (banana rind ash), often used in Assamese cuisine. A crowd favourite at the café, it goes in their dosas, sandwiches, and chilli cheese toasts.

They have also created the Assam Blossom, inspired by alpine cheeses – a distinctive cheddar-style cheese infused with Indian jujube, and coated with an array of spring flowers from Upper Assam.

When Abhilasha started her café, many women from nearby villages wanted to work there, but since café work often requires trained chefs, she could not hire them. "I reached out to some of these women again, as they understood milk and local produce. All I had to teach them was cultures and cheesemaking techniques. Now we're a small team of four women, all from villages around Dibrugarh," Abhilasha says.

Queso cheese is available at Windsong Cafe, Convoy Road, Dibrugarh, and it starts at ₹280 (150 grams of Chilli Cumin Cheddar). The brand also delivers most of its hard-aged cheese across India, and fresh cheeses across Assam.

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If cities could speak

At Heirloom Cities, the culinary history, culture, and community spirit of cities are captured in words



Pages from *Mumbai*; (below) a snapshot of *Kolkata*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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For many Indians, especially those living abroad, the pandemic not just caused a shift in their professional calling but brought them closer to their roots. Take for instance Sri Bodanapu, a marketing professional based in San Francisco, who switched careers to kickstart Heirloom Cities (a publishing house and storytelling project) in 2023. Here, she documents cities through a culinary and cultural lens. The series started off with *Mumbai* (May 2025, ₹5,100) and the second title *Kolkata* (₹7,500) launched this week.

Sri moved to the US 20 years ago, and that move led her to learn how to cook. "It helped me stay connected to my home in Hyderabad. I moved to India for two years during the pandemic and the seed for Heirloom Cities was sown then," she says, adding how her mother's brother, a scientist in the US, had started documenting their family recipes 40 years ago.

"Post my tech career, I turned his document into a book called the *Heritage of Food*. I wanted to preserve our traditions and as an immigrant it was even more important for me." Sri then started a company offering design services to families who were keen to put together their cookbooks, and worked on several books for Indian, Italian, Jewish, and even Lebanese families.

The idea, she explains, was to explore cities for their food and also showcase diversity, local markets, home kitchens, communities, and more. In *Mumbai*, there are essays on chai

nashta, how key spices like the Sunday masala have shaped recipes, how the bun-maska tradition came to be, the micro history of the city's dining out culture, and more.

In *Kolkata*, the narrative shifts to its storied nightlife, history of street food, and the iconic Durga Pujo.

"Mumbai and Kolkata are both influenced by colonisation and urbanisation, and I wanted to highlight that. They are rooted in history, yet evolved. From street food to sushi, their culinary evolution is beautiful and deserves to be documented," says Sri.

Sri says research for *Kolkata* was an entirely different experience from *Mumbai*. "It was like we had stepped into the 1970s with Ambassadors plying the streets and buildings in brick. I felt Mumbai was rushing forward and Kolkata had a slower pace."

Recalling her first meal in Kolkata, Sri says it was a thali at the East India Room at the

Raajkuttir. "I sat down at the table believing I

understood Indian food fairly well; and then plates of mutton pantheras and bhetki macher jhol appeared; dishes I'd never even seen before. Three years later, I still think about that meal."

After *Kolkata*, Sri is turning her gaze to West Asia and looking at similar titles for Dubai and other countries.

"Asian cities have not received their due, and I want to highlight their stories with a focus on food, art, and heritage," she says. "In Dubai everyone focusses on the glitz and glamour, but there is so much more. In current times, we have polarised views of this part of the world and I hope to change that."

The books are available online

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Malayam

A light-hearted film



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At the centre of director Vishnu Aravind’s *Madhuvidhu* is a house where three generations of men live in harmony. Unlike the Anjooran household in *Godfather* (1991), women aren’t banned here; they simply choose not to come. For the protagonist, Amrithraj alias Ammu (Sharafudheen), 28 marriage proposals came through but not a single moved to the next stage.

When a not-so-cordial first meeting with Sneha (Kalyani Panicker) inevitably turns into mutual attraction, things appear to change. However, some unexpected hiccups are waiting for them as they belong to different religions. Writers Jai Vishnu and Bipin Mohan don’t seem to have any major ambitions with *Madhuvidhu*, but they seem rather content to aim for the middle space of a feel-good entertainer. But even with that, they end up hitting further lower.

Much of the first half proceeds in a light-hearted manner, without making much of an impression. The family dynamics and the budding romance evoke only mild interest, until the writers reveal their trump card towards interval. This sets up the conflict quite nicely, but the writers fail to exploit the possibilities fully while building newer and similar conflicts, all of it meant to create an obstacle for the couple. If the movie still remains watchable, it has to do with the strength of the performers and the humour breaks out of peculiar situations.

But there is only so much that mild levels of humour can do, when the film hurtles from one contrived situation to the next. Some of the conflicts are so feeble that it requires one or the other character to act illogically and out of character, like a scene where someone suddenly loses his cool and slaps a person when everyone has finally found peace. A procession of such inexplicable situations, which does not add any emotional heft to the film, also ends up spoiling much of the fun too. Behind all the confusion, one can see the frameworks of a lost opportunity.

Sharafudheen, who proved his mettle in a variety of roles, has found his comfortable space in such light-hearted roles, where his pleasant presence and controlled performance are enough to carry the film for a while. In *Madhuvidhu*, he is ably supported by reliable performers such as Jagadish, Sai Kumar and Azees Nedumangad. Yet, their hard work is not enough to lift the film beyond the average zone, as the writing leaves much to be desired.

Madhuvidhu is currently running in theatres

Madhuvidhu

Director: Vishnu Aravind

Cast: Sharafudheen, Kalyani Panicker, Jagadish, Sai Kumar

Plot: As an inter-religious couple prepares for marriage, an unforeseen turn of events disrupts their plans



Wedding sans the wow factor

An undercooked family entertainer that is occasionally fun and warm thanks to Avinash Tiwary and Medha Shankr’s sincerity

Hindi

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Bollywood’s arranged-marriage factory fires up again with a rom-com that feels cliched and worn out.

The spiritual sequel to the 2020 original, once again trots out the familiar template: a gruff, Rishikesh-based wrestler (Avinash Tiwary) and an effervescent Delhi girl (Medha Shankr) thrown into an arranged match built on mutual lies and family fabrications.

Haunted by a false charge of sexual harassment, Sunny is quietly hoping for a traditional, home-loving wife who fits neatly into his departed mother’s image. Brought up by a single mother (Lillete Dubey), Ginny is the sharp, outgoing Delhi girl with a lively personality, call-centre job, and zest that refuses to be tamed. A broken relationship makes her look for someone simple and caring. Matrimonial advertisements bring them together, but both families peddle convenient fabrications to push the alliance through, only for the truth – and the invisible incompatibility – to unravel in loud, predictable waves of drama.

Writer-director Prasshant Jha tries to mine humour and heart from a clash of cultures and mindsets, but in 2026, the setup feels forced and regressive rather than refreshing. His idea of a modern girl and a small-town boy with a devout friend

Ginny Wedss Sunny 2

Director: Prasshant Jha

Cast: Avinash Tiwary, Medha Shankr, Sudhir Pandey, Lillete Dubey, Govind Namdev, Vishwanath Chatterjee

Synopsis: A small-town wrestler whose reputation is ruined by a viral video resorts to lies in his matrimonial profile to find a bride, while the lively Delhi girl and her mother do the same on their side to arrange the match.



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is drawn from countless Bollywood films rather than from real life. His observational humour attempts to make it appear forward-looking through scattered nods to equality, calling out family expectations, and the messiness of post-wedding realities built on deception. Yet, it falls between the two stools – never fully embracing bold, nuanced commentary on modern compatibility, nor wholeheartedly committing to the old-school formula.

The setup harks back to familiar tropes. Opposites attract, lies that snowball into marital discord, and a noisy ensemble of relatives delivering broad comedy and sentimental life lessons. The problem is that the ingredients don’t come together organically. The screenplay feels like a loosely assembled potpourri of skits rather than a cohesive, tightly woven narrative. One misses dramatic momentum, character progression, and earned payoffs.

The central conceit of mutual deception is a promising hook that the film fails to handle with the care, cleverness, or emotional logic it deserves. It turns what could have been a sharp, layered exploration of trust, vulnerability, and post-marriage incompatibility issues into a superficial engine for repetitive chaos.

With a high-profile lineup of playback singers, the soundtrack could have provided emotional weight to what the writer fails to express, but the songs fail to resonate and struggle to rise above generic wedding masala. When the makers don’t have faith in the strength of the joke, they add funny sounds to the background score. It’s basically admitting

defeat. It is like we don’t trust our writing or timing, so here’s some auditory laugh-track to force the chuckle.

However, a few repartees and dialogues, written by Prashant himself, are among the bright spots, effectively capturing the essence of character in emotional confrontations and lighter banter among the seasoned warhorses Sudhir Pandey, Govind Namdev, and the reliable Vishwanath Chatterjee.

The performances of Avinash and Medha – along with solid support from veterans – are the main factors preventing total disengagement. The pairing generates effortless chemistry in patches. The confrontations in the second half are heartfelt, making the opposites-attract dynamic feel lived-in. Some of Prasshant’s nicely observed lines land better because the leads deliver them with conviction, turning scattered dialogues into momentary highs.

In his first masala entertainer, so to speak, Avinash is a little more reserved than the role requires, which, along with intensity, also demands a young Sunny Deol or Varun Dhawan kind of goofiness. The restraint, which works beautifully for him in more dramatic or nuanced roles, feels a touch under-energised in a noisy narrative. He ends up carrying a lot on quiet sincerity alone, while the film around him leans harder into volume. Medha seems more naturally aligned with the film’s upbeat, chaotic energy, but eventually the listless writing and moth-eaten set-up fail to sustain her spirit.

Ginny Wedss Sunny 2 is currently running in theatres.

A witty fantasy drama propelled by fine performances

Kannada

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Even as director Srinidhi Bengaluru establishes *Jerax*’s fantasy genre in the first scene, which involves a deity and a boy with a special trinket, it’s the characters that we fall in love with rather than the unique premise. By introducing us to a series of relatable people, Srinidhi succeeds in grounding his high-concept plot.

Prakasha (Nagabhushana) runs his uncle’s (a hilarious Om Prakash Rao) Xerox shop, but makes little money thanks to his rusty machine. His uncle doesn’t miss a chance to insult him. Prakasha yearns for solace in his relationship, but his girlfriend Sooji (Payal Chengappa) often expresses her displeasure with his inability to earn well. Parallel to Prakasha’s life, a political rivalry is brewing as Rayadurga witnesses the election battle between politicians Deepu and Ramanna.

Jerax’s world-building becomes



interesting when the inefficient machine starts to show its magic. Prakasha’s mundane life comes alive when he discovers his Xerox machine’s power to clone people. A thrilled Prakasha vows to conquer Rayadurga and earn respect with the help of his secret weapon.

The confusion stemming from identity mix-ups drives the narrative. Srinidhi’s smart writing ensures the cliffhanger endings of episodes expand the plot, which gets meatier with the introduction of Revanth (Yashwanth Shetty), a high-income youngster who becomes a thorn in Prakasha’s love life.

The rules of the fantasy world are quite intriguing, and Srinidhi sticks to them for most of the series. The unusual events are made believable thanks to a great cast. Nagabhushana is convincing. Bigg Boss fame Manju Pavagadda and Santhosh show how solid roles ensure their talent isn’t restricted to reality shows. Yashwanth Shetty and Payal Chengappa also make fine transitions from social media/YouTube space to cinema.

The full potential of *Jerax* feels compromised in the last act. I wish the story had some room for Prakasha to

blossom with his new invention, as it promised early on. Instead, the protagonist is left to rescue his girlfriend from trouble. The idea lacks bite because the relationship doesn’t resonate emotionally. And the political angle is quite plain at its core, despite being propelled by fine performances.

Jerax

Director: Srinidhi Bengaluru

Cast: Nagabhushana, Payal Chengappa, Om Prakash Rao, Manju Pavagadda, Santhosh, Yashwanth Shetty

Runtime: 6 episodes

Storyline: What if a simple machine could change everything? In Rayadurga, Prakasha’s life takes an unexpected turn after a strange discovery in his Xerox shop.

I wish Srinidhi had gone a bit wild with the clones. They add spice to the story, but the writing makes them overly simplistic as they are mostly shown as confused and indecisive. The hurried final episode lays bare the perils of aiming high within the confines of a series that has the features of a “mini series” (20 minutes per episode).

That said, *Jerax* defies odds by being an ambitious original in a platform known for playing it safe. I hope this creative attempt creates a demand for more such shows from the platform’s regular users, who are mostly subjected to conventional dramas.

Srinidhi and team also make a mockery of a common complaint from Kannada filmmakers about the lack of big budgets for fantasy themes. *Jerax* is out-of-the-box, light-hearted, and engaging despite treading the traditional path. Hope this spirited approach to filmmaking sets a good precedent in the Kannada web-series space.

Jerax is currently streaming on Zee5

Invincible
Season 4

Creator:

Robert Kirkman

Cast:

Steven Yeun, Sandra Oh, J.K. Simmons, Walton Goggins, Jeffrey Dean Morgan, Christian Convery, Gillian Jacobs, Lee Pace, Indira Varma

Episodes:

8

Storyline:

The battle lines are drawn between the coalition of planets and the rampaging Viltrumites even as Invincible, Eve, Debbie, Oliver and Nolan process the changes in their lives

Moving from strength to strength

Streaming

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The bone-crushing violence in the fourth season of *Invincible* is horrifying, with its decapitations, eye-gouging and disembowelments. Picking up where season 3 left off with the battle royale between Mark/Invincible (Steven Yeun) and the all powerful Viltrumite, Conquest (Jeffrey Dean Morgan), Season 4 looks at the physical and mental

cost of fights to the death... of people and planets. We learn some of Mark's Viltrumite father Nolan's (JK Simmons) backstory. Nolan's growing up was most definitely not clouds and puppies. As a young Viltrumite, he had to undergo a brutal initiation to prove himself an adult. Nolan has seen the error of his ways and wishes to make reparation for the horrible things he has done. Naturally no one is willing to believe him or welcome him with open arms, including his wife and Mark's mother, Debbie (Sandra Oh), and Cecil (Walton Goggins) the director of the Global Defense Agency, the secret organisation responsible for all things superhero. Nolan's tentative reaching out to Debbie is one of the strengths of the show ("I am a 1,000 years old but 20 years with you made me human"). Debbie's tentative foray into the dating world is met with bittersweet reactions from Mark and his step-brother Oliver (Christian Convery). Mark and Eve (Gillian Jacobs) have to make grown up decisions, including meeting Eve's decidedly frosty parents, all while the fate of the world as we know it is in the hands of a few very angry and very powerful Viltrumites. Oliver is another fascinating character. Idolising his father, Nolan, he is crushed to hear what Nolan says about his mother, even after Nolan assures him that he did not mean it quite like that. Conquest escapes and heads off to Viltrum to tell the Grand Regent Thragg (Lee Pace) of his failure to eliminate Mark. A coalition of planets, headed by Thaedus (Peter Cullen), gathers to defeat the Viltrumites. Thragg is breathing fire and brimstone and wants to avenge the death of Emperor Argall (Frank Welker), who seems a particularly nasty specimen from all the available information. The Viltrumites are on the lookout for the Betrayer – the one who developed the Scourge virus to wipe them out. Allen the Alien (Seth Rogen) provides much of the humour, including telling the coalition that he does not appreciate

their "angriness and blame-ness" after they tell him they do not appreciate his "flippant-ness". Humour-wise, there is also Volcanikka (Indira Varma) grandly telling Damien Darkblood (Clancy Brown), "Tell Satan I am the Great Beast now and he is nothing." Satan (Bruce Campbell), incidentally, looks quite cuddly. The finale ups the stakes further, with Mark having to make a heartbreaking deal, and Debbie and Nolan heading off on an intergalactic trip to discover themselves and check on Oliver. The post-credit sequence shows Allen receiving a message from beyond the grave and having to make a decision that will have terrible consequences for human beings. The voice work is exemplary and the animation kinetic. With *Invincible* conceived as an eight-season arc, we are at the halfway mark, setting things up nicely for the seasons to follow.

Invincible is currently streaming on Amazon Prime Video

Snippets



Sanjay Dutt announces sequel to his 1993 classic, teaser unveiled
Actor Sanjay Dutt announced a sequel to his 1993 classic *Khalnayak*. Titled *Khalnayak Returns*, the film is said to be an interpretation of the original, which was directed by Subhash Ghai and also starred Jackie Shroff and Madhuri Dixit in key roles. Dutt unveiled a teaser of the sequel, which features him reprising the role of Ballu, the iconic anti-hero from the original. The actor thanked Ghai for allowing him to make *Khalnayak* again. "The journey of *Khalnayak* has been long and without Subhash ji it wouldn't have been possible," Dutt told reporters. Meanwhile, Dutt will be seen next in Riteish Deshmukh's *Raja Shivaji*, set to be released on May 1.



Inspector Avinash Season 2 sets JioHotstar premiere
The crime drama *Inspector Avinash* is gearing up for its second season, with JioHotstar confirming the return of Randeep Hooda in the lead role. The upcoming chapter is a continuation of the story, set once again in 1990s Uttar Pradesh, following the titular Inspector Avinash Mishra as tested against new threats Randeep Hooda, who reprises the titular role, described the evolution of his character. The series expands its ensemble with performances from Urvashi Rautela, Amit Sial, Abhimanyu Singh, Rajneesh Duggal, Shalin Bhanot and Freddy Daruwalla. *Inspector Avinash* Season 2 will premiere soon on JioHotstar.



Bandar: Bobby Deol-Anurag Kashyap film gets new release date
Anurag Kashyap's upcoming film, *Bandar* has got a new release date. The Bobby Deol starrer, which was earlier set for a May 22 release, will now hit the theatres on June 5, the makers announced on April 27 through a press release. Written by Sudip Sharma and Abhishek Banerjee, known for *Paatal Lok*, *Kohrra*, and *Udta Punjab*, *Bandar* also stars Sanya Malhotra, Raj B Shetty, Jitendra Joshi, Sapna Pabbi, Indrajith Sukumaran, Riddhi Sen, Saba Azad and Nagesh Bhosle in pivotal roles. The film will now clash at the box office with Kannada superstar Yash's *Toxic*, which will be released on June 4. It marks the first collaboration between Deol and Kashyap and is said to be inspired by real events.



The man in the mirror

Antoine Fuqua delivers a disappointing look at the life of the King of Pop, revealing little about the person behind the explosive music brought to life by Jaafar Jackson

English

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Michael Jackson electrified successive generations with his moves, whoops and fashion. Watching him do the moonwalk inspired many to try that fluid backward-forward slide. For all who were awestruck by his kinetic dance moves, the elaborate movie-style music videos and mind-boggling songs, Antoine Fuqua's *Michael* promises a jolly time at the movies. Those, however, looking to understand the man who single-handedly changed the grammar of the entertainment industry, and whose later life was plagued by child sex abuse allegations, multiple surgeries, drug abuse and bankruptcy, are bound to be disappointed by *Michael*. Starting with a backlit, ponytailed Michael Jackson (Jaafar Jackson) walking on stage to thunderous applause to the frenzied beat of "Wanna Be Startin' Somethin'", *Michael* goes back to 1966, Gary, Indiana. Joseph Jackson (Colman Domingo), a steelworker and a strict disciplinarian, drills his five sons, Jermaine (Jayden Harville), Marlon (Jaylen Lyndon Hunter), Tito (Judah Edwards), Jackie (Nathaniel

Michael

Director: Antoine Fuqua

Starring: Jaafar Jackson, Nia Long, Julianio Valdi, Keilyn Durrel Jones, Laura Harrier, Jessica Sula, Mike Myers, Miles Teller, Colman Domingo

Storyline: The story of Michael Jackson from his beginnings in the Jackson 5 to his 1988 'Bad' tour

Logan McIntyre) and Michael (Juliano Krue Valdi) to perform as a band. Jamal R. Henderson, Tre Horton, Rhyan Hill, Joseph David-Jones with Jaafar Jackson, Michael Jackson's nephew, play the older versions of the Jackson 5. The movie shows Michael being abused by Joseph, who beat him with a belt and denied him a normal childhood, much to the distress of Michael's mother, Katherine (Nia Long). The film follows the Jackson 5's success, leading to their signing with Motown and a move to Encino, California. The president of Motown, Berry Gordy (Larenz Tate), believes Michael has the potential to be a supernova. Moving forward to 1978, the now 20-year-old Michael goes solo with *Off the Wall*, produced by Quincy Jones (Kendrick Sampson). Wishing to be free of Joseph, Michael hires entertainment lawyer John Branca (Miles Teller), to fire him, which he promptly does via fax. Jackson's longtime bodyguard and friend Bill Bray (KeiLyn Durrel Jones) stands by him offering whatever advice he can. *Michael* shows the inspiration behind "Thriller" and "Beat It"; the accident on the set of a Pepsi commercial that presumably got Jackson hooked on painkillers; his animal friends, including Bubbles, the chimpanzee; the cosmetic surgery driven by his consciousness about his nose (the blame for which is placed squarely on Joseph's shoulders); the sold-out Victory

tour; and the public announcement at Dodgers Stadium that he was done touring with his siblings, ending where the film began, in 1988, with Jackson performing 'Bad' at Wembley Stadium. The film was originally meant to mention the sex abuse allegations and their effect on Jackson's life, but a legal ruling barred the reference, forcing the third act to be rewritten. The fact that Branca is one of the producers raises questions about how unbiased the narrative really is. The film briefly acknowledges Jackson's icy resolve in the clinical firing of his father and the certainty of his creative vision, but quickly retreats from it, portraying him instead as an innocent floating through life, more acted upon than acting. Jackson's sister Janet is missing from the film, though La Toya (Jessica Sula) appears. The only thing Mike Myers, as Walter Yetnikoff, president of CBS Records, does is underline the fact that MTV was racist, before pressuring the channel to play 'Billie Jean'. So, while Jaafar Jackson eerily brings his uncle to life, one can always go online for a touch of MJ magic, as the film is so vanilla that it becomes completely disengaging. The King of Pop, who gave us so many hours of joy, deserved far more than what the usually gifted Fuqua gives him here.

Michael is currently running in theatres